

We Don't Do That: State Identity and Nuclear Non-Use*

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Abstract

Is there a taboo against atomic weapons use, and if there is not, how can the public's aversion to it be strengthened? Recent survey experiments conducted in Western states have shown that public opinion is far more receptive to nuclear use than previously thought, with compelling majorities supporting it when it achieves a noteworthy strategic objective. I contribute to this scholarship by fielding a survey experiment in which I present Indian respondents with a hypothetical counterforce attack against Pakistan. Using two treatment arms—one exposing respondents to identity-based appeals and one informing them of India's no first use policy—I test constructivist scholarship arguing that norms' constitutive effects and their institutionalization entrenches public opposition to nuclear weapons. Ultimately, I find little evidence that there is either a nuclear taboo or that identity-based appeals reifies opposition. That said, informing people about India's NFU meaningfully strengthens the public's aversion to nuclear use.

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“While I am convinced of the virtue of non-violence and its power, I am not sure that people in this country, or for that matter of any other country, at the present moment are capable of carrying the burden of non-violence. And if they fail, they fail utterly.”

- Jawaharlal Nehru speaking at the Anti-Nuclear Arms Convention, 1962

1 Introduction

In international relations scholarship, political scientists have often taken after microeconomic theory in assuming that states are rational and selfish (Waltz 1959). Neorealist scholars presuppose that states are strictly security seeking, unmoved by considerations of fairness or altruism in an international system predicated on anarchy and self-help. Since the “constructivist turn,” however, scholars have challenged the descriptive accuracy of assuming states to be egoistic and the international system anarchic (Wendt 1992). Instead, individual leaders, domestic constituencies, and states as units in and of themselves can be constrained by norms of how they are meant to behave.

Crucial to how norms are theorized to affect state behavior is identity (Finnemore and Sikkink 1998). If an action is so morally reprehensible as to contradict a state’s perception of itself, then it will refrain from whatever that action is. Because identity and norms are difficult to measure numerically, constructivist scholars have often resorted to process-tracing and other qualitative means to substantiate their argument that states’ behavior is mediated by ideational factors (Peez 2022). Although these approaches have been useful in illustrating how identity affects elites’ attitudes toward nuclear use (Tannenwald 2007), collateral damage (Crawford 2013), and other norm-breaking behavior, it has limited the scope of constructivist epistemology. The lack of quantitatively-driven, positivist study is striking given that experimental research has shown priming national identity can alter political behavior, such as by reducing affective polarization (Levendusky 2018) or changing attitudes toward immigration (Wojcieszak and Garrett 2018). In this paper, I seek to

redress this methodological gap by fielding a survey experiment in which Indian respondents are exposed to identity-based arguments opposing a hypothetical nuclear attack against Pakistan.

My focus on nuclear weapons follows from scholarship that has characterized non-use as among the strongest norms in the international system. Describing use as repulsive and “taboo,” Nina Tannenwald (2007) contends that non-use is reflexive. Even in dire circumstances, a shibboleth is attached to nuclear weapons, effectively eliminating states’ motivation to use them. Realists have criticized Tannenwald’s argument, saying that if a norm against non-use exists at all, it is epiphenomenal—the product of egoistic states acting out of self-interest (Sagan 2004). To substantiate their argument that no taboo exists, Scott Sagan and Benjamin Valentino have conducted survey experiments revealing that Western public opinion is far more receptive to the use of nuclear weapons than previously thought, with compelling majorities approving of their use in circumstances where they achieve a compelling strategic objective (Press, Sagan and Valentino 2013; Sagan and Valentino 2017; Dill, Sagan and Valentino 2022).

By focusing on India, I test the salience of identity-based arguments in the circumstance where they are most likely to have an effect. Unlike in Western, nuclear armed states, political elites in India have historically framed non-violence as morally obligatory and a touchstone for its foreign policy (Perkovich 2001; Hymans 2006; Mehta 2009; Bajpai 2014). Following World War II, India was among the staunchest proponents of global disarmament and continued to be so even after it tested nuclear weapons. Today, although there is widespread doubt that India would abide by its no first use policy (NFU) during a crisis (Clary and Narang 2019; Sundaram and Ramana 2018), political elites still explicitly assert that first use is antithetical to Indian culture and civilization.

Aside from entertaining how identity affects attitudes toward nuclear weapons use, I consider how the institutionalization of non-use can do the same. Whereas previous studies have focused on how international law can restrict support for nuclear use (Carpenter

and Montgomery 2020; Sagan and Valentino 2024), I consider how NFUs do the same. Whereas international law promotes shared norms, NFUs reinforce perceptions of states' personal identities as being incompatible with nuclear use. This line of argument presents a modification to scholars' understanding of NFUs' credibility. Specifically, it implies that NFUs can trigger audience costs by reifying an image of state identity as being incompatible with nuclear use.

In addition to testing the effects of novel treatments on opposition for nuclear use, I operationalize opposition in a manner that is distinct from recent experimental scholarship on the taboo and better representative of Tannenwald's initial theorizing. Asking respondents whether they would vote against the sitting government for resorting to nuclear use and if they would protest such an attack, among other questions, I gauge the electoral reprisal that political elites would face for using nuclear weapons. Implementing inverse covariance weighting, I create an index that reflects respondents' composite attitudes toward nuclear use, and not strictly overall approval.

Ultimately, the purpose of this thesis is twofold. Narrowly, it contributes to the upswell of survey experiments from the past ten years, in which scholars have sought to understand what factors impact public support for the use of nuclear weapons. It does so by interrogating the effects that state identity and institutionalization can have, and whether those effects are significant in the manner that scholars of the taboo suggest. More broadly, it seeks to evaluate claims in constructivist literature that norms can have a "constitutive effect," in which people's foreign policy preferences are impacted by their impression of state identity (Wendt 1992).

In total, I find little evidence that there is either a taboo against nuclear use in India or that priming conceptions of state identity can reduce opposition to it. A counterforce attack would polarize public opinion in a manner that is inconsistent with there being a taboo, and it even rallies support for the sitting government among those who favor the Bharatiya Janata Party. That said, nuclear use would also foment staunch public opposition to the

government in a way that previous experimental scholarship has not found. Although priming conceptions of state identity does not reduce support for nuclear use, informing people of India's NFU does. This finding has important descriptive and normative implications because it implies that NFUs are costly signals and thus more credible ones (Fearon 1994).

2 Literature Review & Theory

In international relations scholarship, there are two broad theoretical orientations that account for why states behave in the manner that they do: Rationalism and Constructivism (Katzenstein, Keohane and Krasner 1998). Though not wholly incompatible, they differ in their understanding of states' interests and the power of norms in the international system (Fearon and Wendt 2002). As part of these distinct interpretations of how states behave, rationalists argue that all states are fundamentally like one another, doing whatever advances their material interests. Constructivists counter that states have distinct identities which inform how they behave toward others.

Per rationalist scholarship, states exclusively seek to improve their overall material condition (Waltz 1959; Keohane 1984). They may want either security, power, or wealth, but regardless of what they are pursuing, states are rational actors optimizing in the name of that interest. They are egoistic, concerned with other states only insofar as they may be an impediment to or an instrument for the realization of a strategic objective. If norms exist at all in the international system, they are epiphenomenal (Sagan 2004). That is to say, they are not rooted in moral reasoning but stem from states acting in a manner consistent with whatever they believe to be in their material interests. In this formulation, norms do not actually regulate state behavior but are the illusory product of states behaving rationally.

Because rationalists assume that states desire comparable material objectives, there is no role for identity in shaping policy. Rather, all states are like one another in their needs. For realists, the international system is like Hobbes' state of nature. Unconstrained by an